

What else do I want you to *know*?

I came to you having already committed. The decision to build Ikwe in Iowa — to stay, to sign the lease, to put my name on this work here — was made before the accelerator. Iowa State didn't create the commitment. It confirmed it.

I've been running this as a solo operator on founder contributions alone. That's not a complaint — it's context. It means that every benchmark, every pitch, every research finding, every conversation in motion right now was built with no runway. It also means we're at the moment where that approach has a ceiling, and what gets us past it is exactly what this program is built to provide.

The infrastructure is real. The research is original. The IP is locked. The pipeline is ignited. What we need now is to close the gap between all of this being in motion and all of this being in market — and that gap is people, capital, and introductions.

Most AI safety work measures what the model says. We measure how the interaction affects the human. That distinction is why this exists, and it's why it's defensible. The hard work is done. What's next is scale.

Here's where the support matters most:

CAPITAL

Non-dilutive funds first — grants, POCR, any available bridge. Founder survival is not a soft ask; it's the structural requirement for everything else to hold. The \$250K SAFE at a \$2–2.5M cap is positioned for September at Startup Week. Revenue pilots before June 12 are the validation path.

PEOPLE

I'm building a lean, commission-forward team. I have two key roles taking shape — a product manager and an operations/partnerships coordinator. I need help structuring those correctly for this stage. And I need a sales function running: founder-led, enterprise-focused, grant-aware.

ACCESS

Introductions are the multiplier. Academic ties specifically — AI ethics faculty, research centers, endowment-connected networks. Co-authorship, advisory roles, research partnerships. These aren't just credibility; they're the category legitimacy that makes enterprise buyers and institutional investors move.

STRUCTURE

I need CEO support. The step from founder to CEO is real, and the business structure decisions ahead — compensation, equity, advisor agreements, partnership terms — need to be made correctly. This is a longevity play. I want to get those decisions right now.

Between now and September, the sequence is clear: pilots close before Entrefest, live market validation goes into the pitch, and the raise happens at Startup Week. Everything is already in play. The GTM accelerates what's already moving — it doesn't start it.

I've done the foundational work that almost no one does at this stage. The research is original. The benchmark is started and expanding faster than any competitor could replicate because of where we already are. The thesis is proven. The positioning is locked.

What I need most is to not do the next phase alone.

Here's where I'm at. Here's what I need.

And I'm genuinely excited to get started.

Stephanie Stranko

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